

Retrofitting a commercial RF induction generator into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated annealing system for reactive-metal grain growth

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High-temperature vacuum annealing near a metal’s melting point drives controlled grain growth, but it normally requires an expensive turn-key vacuum induction furnace. We describe an open modernization stack (the added control, vacuum, and temperature-feedback hardware and software) that converts a bare commercial radio-frequency (RF) induction generator into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated annealing system with pyrometer feedback. The modernization stack consists of analog power control through LabVIEW and a data-acquisition (DAQ) device, dual-wavelength optical temperature feedback, a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and an in-house machined graphite crucible that serves as a susceptor (an RF-absorbing element that heats the charge it encloses) for metal specimens. Because its only requirement is a monotonic analog power-control input, the modernization stack transfers between generators; the reference build uses a 6 kW solid-state generator. The system produced a fixed-geometry power-temperature calibration with $R^2 = 0.991$ over 1200–1400 °C. Eight nickel anneals at 1200 °C for 12 h reproduced their soak temperature (the constant-temperature hold) to 1201.2 ± 1.3 °C, and soaks up to 40 h at 1325 °C remained stable. In the annealed nickel, optical metallography and scanning electron microscopy (SEM) resolve equiaxed grains and deep thermal grooves, several spanning the full sheet thickness; electron backscatter diffraction (EBSD) maps index hundreds of grains, quantifying grain size and texture. A modified sample stack (the stacked specimen, susceptor, and supports inside the chamber) extends the furnace to non-coupling ceramics, demonstrated by coarsening yttria-stabilized zirconia (YSZ) grains in 45 min at 2500 °C. Complete design files, bill of materials, control software, and data are openly available.

Keywords: induction furnace; grain growth; vacuum annealing; LabVIEW; pyrometer; open-source hardware

I. INTRODUCTION

High-temperature annealing near a metal’s melting point drives controlled grain growth. This is central to studying microstructure-property relationships in metals such as nickel and iron^{1–5}. Growing grains without oxidizing the sample requires temperatures of 1400 to 1500 °C along with high vacuum or an inert atmosphere^{6,7}. Commercial vacuum induction furnaces that meet these requirements are closed, turn-key systems costing \$50k to \$200k or more. Resistive tube and box furnaces reach lower temperatures with slower ramps, and they offer no susceptor route to charges that do not couple to the RF field. Bare industrial induction generators are widely available, but they ship without vacuum, optical temperature feedback, or computer setpoint control.

This work adds that missing modernization stack. A bare RF induction generator^{8,9} is retrofitted into a full annealing system with computer power control, closed-loop optical temperature feedback, a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and a machined graphite crucible that doubles as a susceptor. The modernization stack is deliberately generator-agnostic. Its only requirement is an analog power-control input, such as 4–20 mA or 0–5 V, with a monotonic command-to-power response. The pyrometer feedback and proportional–integral–derivative (PID) calibration absorb any nonlinearity in that response. The generator internals are not reproduced, so a

compatible generator needs to be supplied. The graphite crucible couples strongly to the RF field and serves the metal grain-growth charges. Non-coupling ceramics such as YSZ use a modified sample stack in which graphite or tantalum serves as the susceptor, chosen for chemical compatibility with the specimen (Sec. V A).

The reproducible build documented here is anchored on a current, USA-sourced 6 kW solid-state generator whose controller accepts a standard 4–20 mA power setpoint. The package of generator, heating head, controller, and chiller was quoted at approximately \$16.5k. The retrofit components are itemized in the bill of materials in the supplementary material. This is a small fraction of turn-key cost, in a form the user can repair and modify.

II. SYSTEM DESIGN AND DESCRIPTION

The system comprises five subsystems (Fig. 1(a)). Figure 1(b) shows the assembled system at operating power.

The heating subsystem is a 6 kW solid-state induction generator driving a liquid-cooled copper work coil. The coil is approximately 3 in tall and 2.5 in in inner diameter, with 6.5 turns tuned to the sample stack^{10,11}. The coil conductors carry both the RF current and the coolant. Ethylene glycol coolant flows in series from the chiller through the generator and then through the heating head and work coil before returning to the chiller.

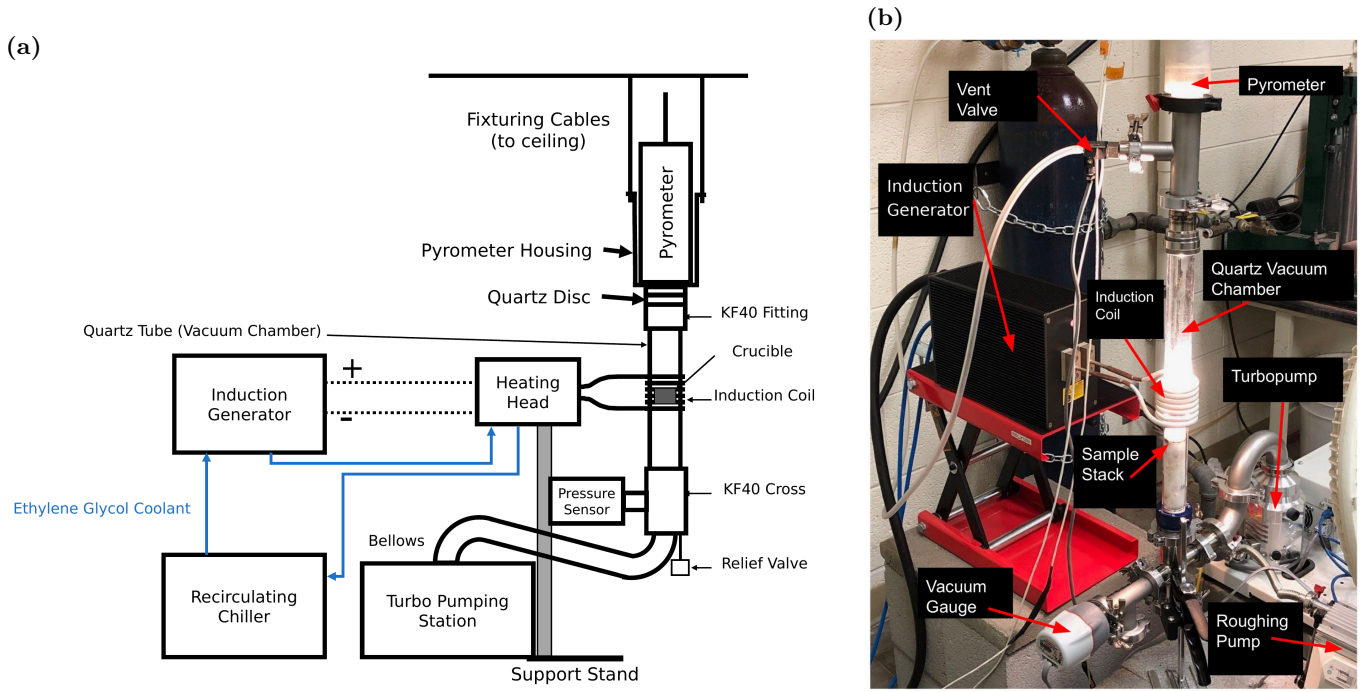


FIG. 1. The annealing system. (a) System overview. The generator drives the liquid-cooled heating head and work coil around the vertically suspended quartz-tube chamber. The quartz tube is joined by KF40 flanges to the ceiling-suspended pyrometer housing above and to the vacuum hardware below. An overpressure relief valve and a flexible bellows lead past the pressure sensor to the turbo pumping station. (b) The assembled, functioning furnace with the main components labeled. This shows the quartz chamber glowing at the sample-stack position. The pyrometer sights down the chamber axis, and the vent valve admits the argon backfill. The gauge, turbopump, and separately supported roughing pump complete the vacuum path. Relative to closed turn-key vacuum induction furnaces, this design costs far less, is modular (hand-clamped KF-flanged vacuum hardware and an interchangeable sample stack), and is transparent (open LabVIEW control software and design files), and it reaches a high-purity annealing environment by pumping the chamber to high vacuum and then backfilling with flowing argon.

The vacuum and gas subsystem starts from the 35 mm inner-diameter fused-quartz tube that forms the chamber. The tube connects through a KF40 flange (a standard clamp-sealed vacuum flange) and a flexible bellows to a compact turbo pumping station that reaches 10^{-6} to 10^{-8} Torr. A manual vent valve fed from an inert-gas regulator allows controlled venting and backfilling^{12,13}. The atmosphere matters for graphite-crucible anneals. The best results were achieved by pumping to high vacuum and then backfilling with argon through the vent valve. The chamber was purged first, and a constant argon flow of 20 standard cubic centimeters per minute (SCCM) was then maintained for the duration of the anneal. The nickel grain-growth anneals reported below all ran under this continuous flow. Heating under vacuum alone tended to sublime graphite onto the chamber walls. The highest-temperature ceramic work (Sec. V A) used the same continuous argon supply, with the chamber evacuated and then filled with argon while the turbopump was running. This helped avoid oxidation during heating.

Temperature is sensed optically. A dual-wavelength ratio pyrometer^{14,15} with an 800 to 2500 °C sensing range views the sample through a KF40 optical window. This

provides a non-contact signal that is robust to emissivity changes and to the RF field that would corrupt thermocouples^{16–18}. Control is implemented in LabVIEW, with virtual instruments (VIs) for manual control, automated ramping, PID tuning, and email alerts. The DAQ device’s 0–5 V analog output drives a voltage-to-current loop conditioner, and the conditioner’s 4–20 mA output lands on the generator’s power-setpoint input. The pyrometer’s analog output returns to a DAQ input, which closes the PID loop. Below the pyrometer’s detection floor of approximately 700 °C, the VI ramps open-loop. Once the pyrometer returns a sustained valid reading, control hands over to closed-loop PID on the optical temperature^{19,20}. Mechanically, a bolted support stand carries the generator’s heating head and centers the work coil on the crucible position. The vacuum chamber itself has no support stand. The quartz tube and the vacuum hardware below it are joined by KF40 flanges to the pyrometer housing, which is suspended from the ceiling by cables, so the vertical column of vacuum hardware hangs from above. The sample stack is not attached to any of these flanges. It simply sits inside the quartz tube.

Metal charges in the graphite crucible reach the nickel and iron grain-growth range of 1400 to 1500 °C, with

demonstrated soaks from minutes to 40 h. The modified ceramic sample stack extends the working range to 2500 °C. The modernization stack transfers to any generator that exposes a monotonic analog power input, supports a liquid-cooled head and coil of the documented geometry, delivers enough RF power for the target charge, and allows electrical isolation of the DAQ and control path. When porting, the command scaling, calibration, PID gains, alignment, and interlock behavior are re-established.

A. Graphite crucible / susceptor

Metal specimens are held in a two-piece graphite crucible machined in-house from 3000 °C-grade graphite stock. It consists of a cup body and a lidded cap with a central bore, which contains the charge while leaving an optical path for the pyrometer. Figure 2(a) shows the disassembled parts. The graphite couples strongly to the induction field and acts as a susceptor, heating the contained metal specimen by conduction and radiation. The specimen is sandwiched between two alumina discs in the cup, the lid seats on top, and a sapphire window closes the lid bore (Fig. 2(b–d)). Sapphire is used for the window to increase transmittance in the wavelength ranges emitted from the sample relative to the pyrometry. When fully assembled the crucible stands 13 mm tall, and the measured dimensions of every piece are given in the supplementary material. Inside the vacuum chamber the crucible rests on an alumina support rod that positions it at coil height, with graphite cement rather than discarded. The crucible primarily serves the metal grain-growth charges. Graphite also works as a susceptor for some ceramic charges when the contact chemistry permits. Sec. V A describes how a compatible susceptor is selected for refractory ceramics.

III. CONSTRUCTION AND OPERATION

Following the heating path, the generator’s heating head mounts on an adjustable platform on the bolted support stand so the coil centers on the crucible position of the vertically suspended quartz tube. The vacuum path begins at the quartz tube, whose open end terminates in a KF40 flange closed by a 55 mm quartz optical disc. Every flanged joint compresses an elastomer O-ring carried on a centering ring, so the vacuum hardware assembles with hand-tightened clamps and no tools. These seals support the 10^{-6} to 10^{-8} Torr operating vacuum. From the bottom of the vacuum column, a tee carries a 0.5 psi overpressure relief valve that protects the quartz tube during backfilling. A flexible bellows continues through the wide-range vacuum gauge to the turbo pumping station. The roughing pump sits on a separate support, mechanically decoupled so its vibration does not reach the chamber or the pyrometer sight

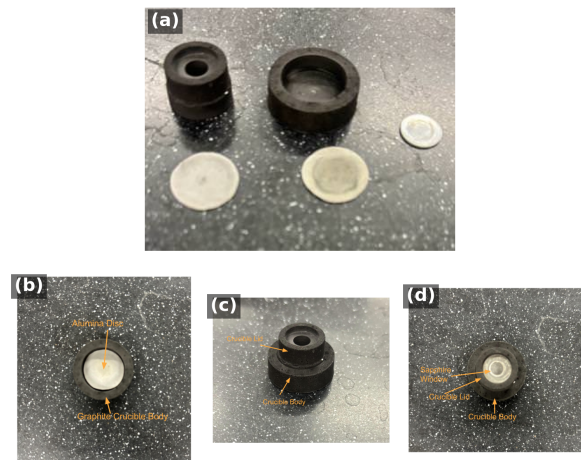


FIG. 2. The two-piece graphite crucible/susceptor used for the nickel anneals reported in this work. (a) Fully disassembled. Top left is the crucible lid, top middle is the bottom of the crucible that acts as the specimen carrier, far right is the sapphire window, bottom left and middle are the alumina sample-surrounding sheets. (b–d) Specimen-loading sequence. (b) The specimen is placed between two alumina sheets in the crucible body. (c) The graphite lid is seated on top. (d) The sapphire window closes the lid bore, leaving an optical path for the pyrometer.

line. Photographs of the pumping station as installed, together with the relief valve at the base of the vacuum column, are given in the supplementary material. On the gas path, the argon regulator feeds the manual vent valve. A mass flow controller between them is helpful when continuous inert gas flow is required. On the control path, electrical isolation is maintained between the DAQ wiring and the generator interface. Manual control is verified before automated ramping and soaking are enabled.

A run begins with the chamber vented, which is done only after the turbo pump has stopped spinning. The specimen is loaded into the crucible (Fig. 2(b–d)), the sample stack is lowered into the quartz tube, and the chamber is pumped down. The LabVIEW profile ramps open-loop below the pyrometer floor, hands over to closed-loop PID, and runs the programmed soak. Afterwards the sample cools under vacuum, and the chamber is vented only once the turbo pump has stopped.

IV. PERFORMANCE VALIDATION

The furnace has completed more than one hundred logged anneals of Ni200 and Ni (4N5, i.e., 99.995 % purity) nickel charges, and of palladium thermal-evaporation charges, at 900 to 1400 °C, with soaks from minutes to 40 h. The supplementary material links each result below to its underlying run log.

For one fixed configuration of Ni (4N5) specimen,

quartz tube, graphite crucible, and optics, four steady-state anneals spanning 1200 to 1400 °C give a monotonic relation between the soak-mean analog power command and the soak-mean pyrometer temperature. The relation is well described by $T = 931 + 632 I$, with T in °C and I in mA, and $R^2 = 0.991$. The offset shifts with charge and optical configuration, so this is an operational calibration for a given setup, not a universal command–temperature law. A Ni (4N5) anneal at a nominal 1300 °C and 12 h condition serves as the representative closed-loop run, and its trace is given in the supplementary material. The soak held 1302.1 ± 3.0 °C over the 12 h plateau. The 10–90 % rise time was approximately 1135 s, the overshoot was approximately 12 °C, and the drift was a negligible -0.02 °C per hour.

Eight Ni (4N5) anneals at a nominal 1200 °C and 12 h condition were run under the same gas-flow configuration. They reproduced their soak temperature to 1201.2 ± 1.3 °C, a coefficient of variation of 0.11 %. Long-duration stability was demonstrated with two Ni200 anneals at 1325 °C. The first held for 20 h at 1326.5 ± 1.5 °C with a drift of -0.004 °C per hour, and the second held for 40 h. Figures for both are in the supplementary material. Reported temperatures are closed-loop ratio-pyrometer readings in a fixed optical geometry. Absolute specimen temperature still depends on emissivity and surface condition^{16,21,22}.

V. MICROSTRUCTURAL VALIDATION

The furnace exists to change microstructure, so the decisive test is what the anneals do to real specimens. A striking feature of that test is that it required no metallographic sample preparation at all. The EBSD specimens shown here were never ground, polished, or etched. Each was pulled directly from the furnace chamber and placed directly into the EBSD chamber. Figure 3 shows a raw EBSD pattern, also called a Kikuchi pattern, from such an unprepared furnace-annealed nickel specimen, reproduced exactly as the EBSD detector saved it during orientation mapping. Even at the coarse 8×8 binning used for mapping, the bands and zone axes are crisply resolved. Preparation-free EBSD works here for two reasons. EBSD diffracts from only the top tens of nanometers of the surface, and the long near-solidus anneal removes the deformed near-surface layer that polishing normally exists to remove²³. In addition, the evacuated, argon-flowing, graphite-enclosed environment holds the oxygen potential low, which plausibly keeps the surface free of an EBSD-obscuring nickel oxide scale²⁴. Rapid nickel surface diffusion at these temperatures can further smooth the surface^{25,26}. The same surface transport produces the deep boundary grooves described below, which can locally reduce indexing right at the boundaries²⁷. Inverse-pole-figure maps built from such patterns resolve hundreds of indexed grains per specimen (Fig. 4). Each indexed color in the map is a crystallographic orientation,

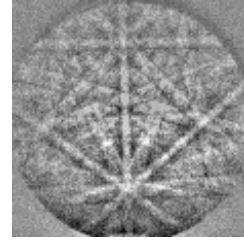


FIG. 3. Raw EBSD Kikuchi pattern from a furnace-annealed nickel specimen that received no sample preparation whatsoever — no grinding, polishing, or etching. The specimen was pulled directly from the furnace chamber and placed directly into the EBSD chamber. The pattern is reproduced exactly as saved by the EBSD detector during orientation mapping (the detector’s 8×8 -binned output). Even so, the crisply resolved bands and zone axes index directly to the nickel lattice.

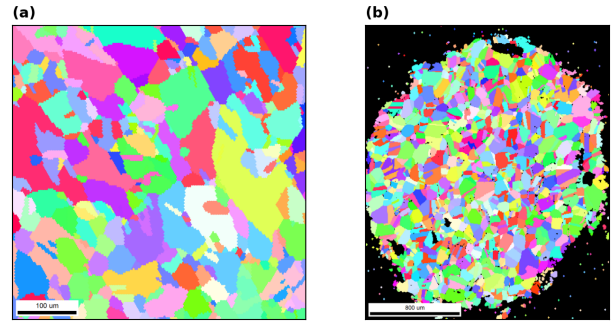


FIG. 4. EBSD inverse-pole-figure (IPF) orientation maps of two furnace-annealed Ni (4N5, 99.995 % purity) specimens, rendered from the recorded EBSD scans. Neither specimen received any sample preparation. (a) A furnace-annealed specimen (100 μm scale bar). (b) A second furnace-annealed specimen (800 μm scale bar). This specimen was masked, which is why indexed points fill only the circular unmasked region against the black surround. The maps resolve hundreds of grains for grain-size and texture analysis. The supplementary material links each specimen to its furnace run.

so a single map records both the grain sizes and the texture of the annealed specimen. Thermal grooving is itself a record of the anneal. Figure 5 shows edge-on views of a Ni (4N5) specimen annealed at 1200 °C for 12 h and cleaned only ultrasonically. The grooves are deep, and several boundaries traverse the full sheet thickness. This is a step toward columnar grain structures²⁸.

Figure 6 shows the microstructure such an anneal produces for a Ni (4N5) specimen soaked 20 h at 1300 °C under the constant 20 SCCM argon flow, with a measured soak of approximately 1301 °C. The optical grain map resolves an equiaxed grain network delineated by thermal grooving alone. Grain-size measurements were made directly in the image against its 200 μm scale bar. The SEM detail resolves an individual boundary groove at the micrometer scale²⁹.

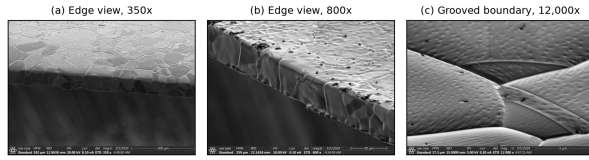


FIG. 5. Grain-boundary thermal grooving on a Ni (4N5) specimen after a 1200°C / 12 h anneal, imaged edge-on in the as-annealed condition after only an ultrasonic ethanol clean. (a) Edge view at $350\times$ ($200\mu\text{m}$ scale bar). Several grain boundaries traverse the full sheet thickness. (b) Edge and top surface at $800\times$ ($50\mu\text{m}$ scale bar). The grooves outline the surface grain structure. (c) A single grooved boundary at $12,000\times$ ($5\mu\text{m}$ scale bar). The deep trench develops as grain-boundary energy equilibrates against surface energy at the soak temperature.

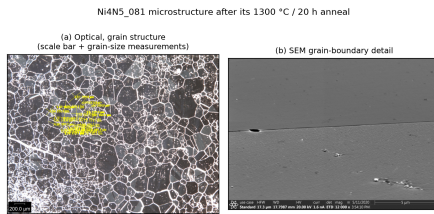


FIG. 6. Microstructure of a Ni (4N5) specimen after a 1300°C / 20 h anneal under a constant 20 SCCM argon flow. (a) Optical grain map with in-image grain-size measurements ($200\mu\text{m}$ scale bar); (b) high-magnification SEM grain-boundary detail.

A. Extension to ceramic charges: YSZ

The same induction furnace can also be used to process refractory ceramics by modifying only the materials directly in contact with the specimen while leaving the generator, vacuum system, pyrometer, cooling system, and control software unchanged. Materials that do not couple directly to the RF field require a susceptor. At the temperatures required for grains to coarsen on refractory ceramics, the primary consideration in selecting a susceptor is its chemical compatibility with the specimen and surrounding support materials rather than its RF heating performance. Graphite and tantalum both serve effectively as susceptors, with the preferred choice depending on the operating temperature and the materials in contact with the susceptor.

Grain growth in refractory ceramics follows Arrhenius kinetics and is therefore highly sensitive to annealing temperature. For the 8mol% YSZ specimens investigated here, grain growth from approximately $10\mu\text{m}$ to $90\mu\text{m}$ required 228 h at 1600°C in a conventional box furnace, whereas comparable grain growth was achieved in only 45 min at 2500°C using the induction furnace (Fig. 7). Achieving these temperatures required only minor modifications to the sample stack (Fig. 8). For example, direct contact between graphite and alumina was eliminated because they undergo a eutectic reaction

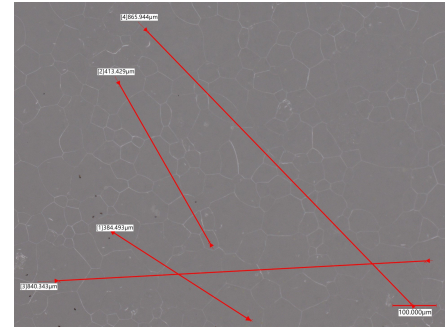


FIG. 7. As-recorded optical micrograph of the YSZ specimen after the 2500°C / 45 min tantalum-susceptor anneal, which coarsened the grains from approximately 20 to $90\mu\text{m}$. The red multi-grain measurement traces and the $100\mu\text{m}$ scale bar are part of the original microscope record.

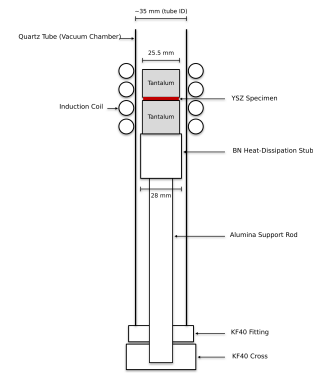


FIG. 8. Sample-stack configuration for the high-temperature ceramic anneals. The YSZ specimen is sandwiched between two 25.5mm tantalum susceptor blocks inside the quartz tube. The blocks rest on a boron nitride heat-dissipation stub, which sits on the alumina support rod that raises the sample stack to coil height. The coil, vacuum, pyrometer, and control paths are unchanged from the metal configuration.

that lowers the interface melting temperature to approximately 1800°C . This was accomplished by introducing a boron nitride diffusion barrier between the two materials. Alternatively, replacing the graphite with tantalum avoids this compatibility issue while still providing efficient RF coupling.

VI. CONCLUSIONS

A bare commercial RF induction generator can be converted into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated, pyrometer-feedback annealing system with a documented, generator-agnostic modernization stack. On a current solid-state generator the modernization stack demonstrated a power-temperature calibration with $R^2 = 0.991$, high soak repeatability, stable closed-loop soaks up to 40 h, and annealed nickel whose surfaces index directly in the EBSD and show controlled grain

growth.

The ceramic extension shows how far the same furnace stretches without redesign. Exchanging only the materials in contact with the specimen carries the system from metal anneals in the graphite crucible to ceramic grain growth at 2500 °C. The trial-and-error survey behind that result identified chemistry, not power, as the governing constraint at extreme temperature. Every failure mode was a contact reaction among the charge, the susceptor, and the support materials. The interchangeable sample stack lets a user iterate on those material choices run by run. Because the modernization stack requires only a monotonic analog power-control input, the design ports across generators and is directly reusable at a small fraction of turn-key cost. The through-thickness boundary grooving points to columnar grain-growth studies as a natural next application.

SUPPLEMENTARY MATERIAL

See the supplementary material for the measured crucible part dimensions, the work-coil drawing, the power-temperature calibration and the representative-soak, repeatability, and long-soak traces, the raw Kikuchi-pattern survey, the tantalum-susceptor heat curves, the YSZ micrographs, the specimen-thermal-history linkage table with links to every raw run log, the itemized bill of materials, and the design-file inventory.

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AUTHOR DECLARATIONS

Conflict of Interest

The authors have no conflicts to disclose.

Ethics Approval

This work did not involve human or animal subjects; ethics approval is not applicable.

Author Contributions

— provisional: **Sterling G. Baird:** Conceptualization, Software, Investigation, Writing – original draft.

Ryan Weber: Investigation, Methodology, Data curation, Visualization. **Christopher Nyborg:** Investigation, Methodology, Data curation, Visualization. **Ronnie Guymon:** Visualization, Writing – review & editing. **Gage Erickson:** Visualization, Writing – review & editing. **Oliver Johnson:** Supervision, Project administration.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The data that support the findings of this study are openly available in the development repository (<https://github.com/vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace>); an archival snapshot is deposited at Zenodo, <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20878017>.

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